

# PAST IMPERFECT

FROM SCAM, SCANDAL AND NEPOTISM TO



Sonia Gandhi at the sugar factory

## SUGAR MILL SCAM

The Sant Muktabai Sahakari Sakhar Karkhana Ltd, Jalgaon, was founded by Patil in 1980 but the project took off only in 1994-95 with a loan from the Mumbai Central District Co-operative Bank. It began operations in 1998, but never broke even and was closed down after 1999. It owes the bank Rs 17.7 crore.

## UPA DEFENCE

I&B Minister P.R. Dasmunshi says not a single case exists under which the candidate has either been charged or probed. NCP chief Sharad Pawar says: "Seventy-four mills were issued notice in 2006. Pratibha was chairperson of the mill only till 2004."

on all the choices. Karat and CPI General Secretary A.B. Bardhan, among the first to arrive along with NCP chief Sharad Pawar and RJD's Lalu Prasad Yadav, indulged in pleasant banter on the Left not sparing a comrade for the post. Banter and ribbing over, Sonia decided to pop the name. Karat said "they didn't know enough about her" to react immediately but Bardhan was instantly sold on the idea as he knew her and described her as "an outstanding choice". Before you could say Pratibha Devisinh Patil, there was all-round applause and she was declared the nominee. Sonia said it would be a matter of great pride for the country to have a woman President in the 60th year of Independence. In less than two weeks, pride has turned into discomfiture and panic.

To start with, Patil had everything going for her—history, geography and caste. Her advocate father Narayan Rao Patil got her to join politics following a fiery speech at the Akhil Bharatiya Rajput Parishad in 1960. By 1962, the practising advocate, who was also a table tennis champion, won her first Assembly election and has since never lost any election. In 1965, she married Devisinh Shekhawat, a Rajput from Amravati, and was part of the then chief minister of

SHRIYA PATIL

Dhage's family in Sungaon



## DRIVEN TO SUICIDE

Kisan Dhage, a teacher at the Nathibai High School in Sungaon run by Devisinh Shekhawat, moved the Bombay High Court and won a case for non-payment of wages. The school trust didn't pay up and Dhage committed suicide blaming Devisinh for it. He was denied bail by a sessions court in February 2007 and has now got a stay from the high court.

## CONGRESS DEFENCE

Dasmunshi says, "How can a man be out so long without bail? I think this is an allegation that needs to be probed. Even if we accept the charge, the question is who is the candidate. Pratibha or her husband?"

Maharashtra Vasantrao Naik's camp. She held all the major portfolios from health to education to urban development, and was leader of the opposition, MPCC chief and deputy chairperson of the Lok Sabha. After 1990, she was in the shadows before being appointed Governor in 2005 by Sonia.

**T**he script that produced Patil's well-crafted persona as a Presidential dead ringer though is running contrary to the story on the ground. A series of allegations, surfacing from Jalgaon, Amravati and Buldana, involving corruption, nepotism, involvement in murder and abetment to suicide, has stained Patil's campaign. You could argue that politicians are vulnerable to allegations at every election. But the fact is that these charges are not being made casually. They are being made about the family of the next possible President of India. This is not just a call for attention. It is a cause for alarm. L.K. Advani, leader of the Opposition in Parliament, put it in perspective when he asked the constituents of the UPA to consider what would happen if the Rashtrapati Bhavan got a tainted occupant, and therefore to cast a conscience vote.